

A ray of hope amid bleak tableau

WEATHER EASES AS SCALE OF LOSSES BEGINS TO TAKE SHAPE



A STAIRWAY and steel beams are all that remain of a house on Pacific Coast Highway after the Palisades fire. The blaze was 8% contained as of Friday afternoon. WALLY SKALIJ Los Angeles Times

Crews making headway in battle

BY HANNAH FRY, NATHAN SOLIS, GRACE TOOHEY AND RICHARD WINTON

An unprecedented four-day fire siege that damaged or destroyed more than 12,000 structures and killed at least 11 people showed signs of finally easing Friday as winds lessened and firefighters began to contain the infernos.

Los Angeles County Fire Chief Anthony Marrone said crews were in their best position yet to get a handle on the blazes — though still with a long way to go. The Palisades fire was 8% contained and the Eaton fire was 3% contained as of Friday afternoon, according to fire officials.

In addition to better weather, the fight has been aided by a stream of firefighting help from far and wide and the ability to use water-dropping aircraft, which were grounded by high winds during the first [See **Wildfires**, A10]



FIREFIGHTERS battle a blaze Wednesday at an apartment complex in Altadena. False evacuation alerts have added to confusion and stress for county residents. GINA FERAZZI Los Angeles Times

Faulty evacuation alerts raise own alarm

Losing public's trust could be catastrophic, ex-controller warns.

BY JENNY JARVIE GRACE TOOHEY AND TERRY CASTLEMAN

County officials apologized Friday after residents across the Los Angeles area continued to receive erroneous emergency alerts that urged them to prepare to

evacuate, even though many were not close to any of the fires sweeping across the foothills of the sprawling metropolis.

Residents were awoken in the middle of the night Friday by the now-familiar buzz and chime: "An EVACUATION WARNING has been issued in your area." Panic ensued as many were left to make a quick decision — was it time to grab their bags and leave?

For some who lived as far

as 20 miles from any active fire, the alert was clearly wrong. But to residents closer to active evacuation zones — many of whom were already on edge after fires have damaged or destroyed more than 12,000 structures — the alerts stoked confusion and panic.

"I can't express enough how sorry I am for this experience," Kevin McGowan, the director of the Los Angeles County Office of Emergency [See **Alerts**, A6]

Did fire budget shrink or grow? Yes to both

Spending has gone up mostly because of pay hikes, but other areas were scaled back.

BY DAVID ZAHNISER

When Mayor Karen Bass unveiled her budget plan for 2024-25, she called for a 2.7% reduction in spending at the Los Angeles Fire Department.

Her proposal, unveiled in April, sought \$23 million in cuts to the department, with much of it focused on reduced equipment pur-

chases. But while her citywide spending proposal was being reviewed, Bass was also in closed-door negotiations over a major boost in pay for the city's 3,300 firefighters. Those pay hikes — four years of raises and an array of other financial incentives — were not finalized until several months after her budget went into effect.

The City Council approved the firefighter raises in November, adding more than \$53 million in additional salary costs. By then, the council had also signed off on \$58 million for new fire trucks and other department purchases.

Once those two line items were added, the Fire Department's operating budget actually grew by more than 7% compared with the prior fiscal year, according to the city's financial analysts.

The issue of Fire Department spending, boring and burdened with specifics in normal times, is now a critical issue in Los Angeles after the massive destruction caused by a wildfire in Pacific Palisades, which continues to burn. The Eaton fire, which has destroyed swaths of Altadena, is out- [See **Budget**, A6]

'I don't have any more tears to cry'

Having to start over, resident of Altadena accepts a new reality.

BY JEFFREY FLEISHMAN

The sky was blue, empty of smoke, as if no ruin had come to the house where Maria Sanchez once lived at the foot of the San Gabriels in Altadena. But as she wandered through the wreckage on Thursday, she stepped amid cinders left by the flames that had swarmed the land and erased the life she had built.

It was quiet on West Palm Street. Ash descended over burned cars, toppled homes, and charred fences and trees. A helicopter skimmed the distance. Firetrucks navigated around fallen power lines. People who once lived here, like Sanchez, walked around in unchanged clothes, humbled and stunned by the force that showed them no mercy a day earlier.

[See **Sanchez**, A8]

At heart of Palisades, repairs left reservoir offline and dry

BY MATT HAMILTON

A large reservoir in Pacific Palisades that is part of the Los Angeles water supply system was out of use when a ferocious wildfire destroyed thousands of homes and other structures nearby, the Los Angeles Times found.

Officials said that the Santa Ynez Reservoir had

been closed for repairs to its cover, leaving a 117-million-gallon water storage complex empty in the heart of the Palisades.

The revelation comes among growing questions about why firefighters ran out of water while battling the blaze. The Times reported early Wednesday that numerous fire hydrants in higher-elevation streets of [See **Reservoir**, A8]



THE SANTA YNEZ reservoir is out of service because of a torn cover. Would its 117-million-gallon capacity have made a big difference for firefighters? HAYLEY SMITH Los Angeles Times

Increasing housing costs

Experts say rents and insurance costs are expected to rise, adding to L.A.'s challenges. **BUSINESS**, A7

'Doomscrolling' in L.A.

Endless carousel of images documents the fear, loss and grief that felt unimaginable. **CALIFORNIA**, B1

Drone disables plane

Collision over the Palisades fire caused firefighting aircraft to be grounded for days. **CALIFORNIA**, B3

Felony sentence for Trump

He becomes the first president with that distinction, though the judge issues no penalty. **NATION**, A4

Misconduct alleged at USC

Top female and Black official in athletic administration says she was fired for raising concerns. **SPORTS**, B12

Weather

Sunny, smoky, hazy. L.A. Basin: 67/47. **B8**



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